

A

Reason

I went home early **because** I was feeling tired.

As/Since I was feeling tired, I went home early. (We don't usually start a sentence with *because*.)

I was feeling tired, **so** I went home early. (This is very common in spoken English.)

The reason I went home early **was that** I was feeling tired.

We can also use **because of** with a different construction. Compare:

They go there **because** the weather is wonderful. (because + noun + verb)

They go there **because of** the wonderful weather. (because of + (adjective) + noun)

Due to means the same as **because of**, and is often used to explain the reason for a problem.

The plane was late **due to** bad weather. (**Due to** is often used after the verb *be*.)

Common mistakes

It's a pity you can't go on holiday **because** Chiclayo is very nice. (NOT It's a pity you can't go on holiday ~~because of~~ Chiclayo is very nice.)

We moved house **because of** my father's work. (NOT We moved house ~~because~~ my father's work.)

B

Purpose

A **purpose** is an intention or reason for doing something.

The **purpose of** the meeting is to plan next year's timetable. [the reason *for* the meeting]

We often introduce a purpose using **so (that)** or **(in order) to**:

I bought this book **so (that)** I **could** improve my English.

They went home early **(in order) to** watch the match on television.

We moved house **so (that)** we **could** send our children to this school.

She went into town **(in order) to** do some shopping.

C

Result

These link words/phrases are used when one thing happens because another thing has happened. **Therefore** and **as a result** are more formal than **so**, and less common in spoken English.

I left my ticket at home, **so** I had to buy another one.

They've got more money, and **therefore** they can afford to buy the best football players.

I forgot to send the email. **As a result**, no one knew about the meeting.

D

Conditions

We sometimes use **whether** [if] when we are not sure about something.

I didn't buy it because I wasn't sure **whether** you'd like it.

I spoke to the others, but I don't know **whether** they're coming.

We'll be late **unless** we leave now. [if we don't leave now]

Unless the weather improves [if the weather doesn't improve], we won't be able to go.

I have to go now, **otherwise** [because if I don't] I'll miss the last bus.

You'll have to turn up the music, **otherwise** [because if you don't] they won't be able to hear it.

You can borrow it **as long as** you bring it back by Thursday. [but you *must* bring it back]

You can wear what you like **as long as** you look quite smart. [but you *must* look quite smart]

I'm taking my umbrella **in case** it rains. [I'm doing A because B might happen later.]

Take some money **in case** you need to get a taxi.